

State Review Learnings:

University of Arkansas – Fort Smith

Traditional Route

On-Site Review: October 23–24, 2025

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

The report uses evidence from state data collection and an onsite review to examine educator preparation program performance. The information in this report is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

This report rates the EPP on all three Standards of the Arkansas Education Preparation Provider State Review Framework, which are fundamental to support teacher candidates in their journey to becoming successful teachers who meet the needs of students in Arkansas:

- Standard 1, “Candidate Recruitment and Completion,” is rated primarily with quantitative data from state data collection.
- For Standard 2, “Preparing Candidates Effectively,” criteria to assess performance results from document review, observations, and focus group conversations with stakeholders, including teacher preparation program deans, candidates, current school leaders and teachers, faculty, and the DESE staff.
- The ratings for Standard 3, “Supporting Workforce Needs,” are based on state data reporting.

Performance Levels are defined as follows:

Performance Level	Average Score Equivalent
EXCEEDS	Average score equivalent to exceeds on two of three standards or indicators
MEETS	Average score equivalent to meets on all three standards or indicators
APPROACHING	Average score equivalent to approaching on one standard or indicator and meets on the other two

BELOW	Average score equivalent to below on one standard or indicator and approaching on the other two
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University of Arkansas - Fort Smith

Traditional Route

Overall Performance Level		
MEETS		
Performance Levels by Standard		
Standard 1: Recruitment & Completion	Standard 2: Preparing Candidates Effectively	Standard 3: Supporting Workforce Needs
MEETS	MEETS	EXCEEDS

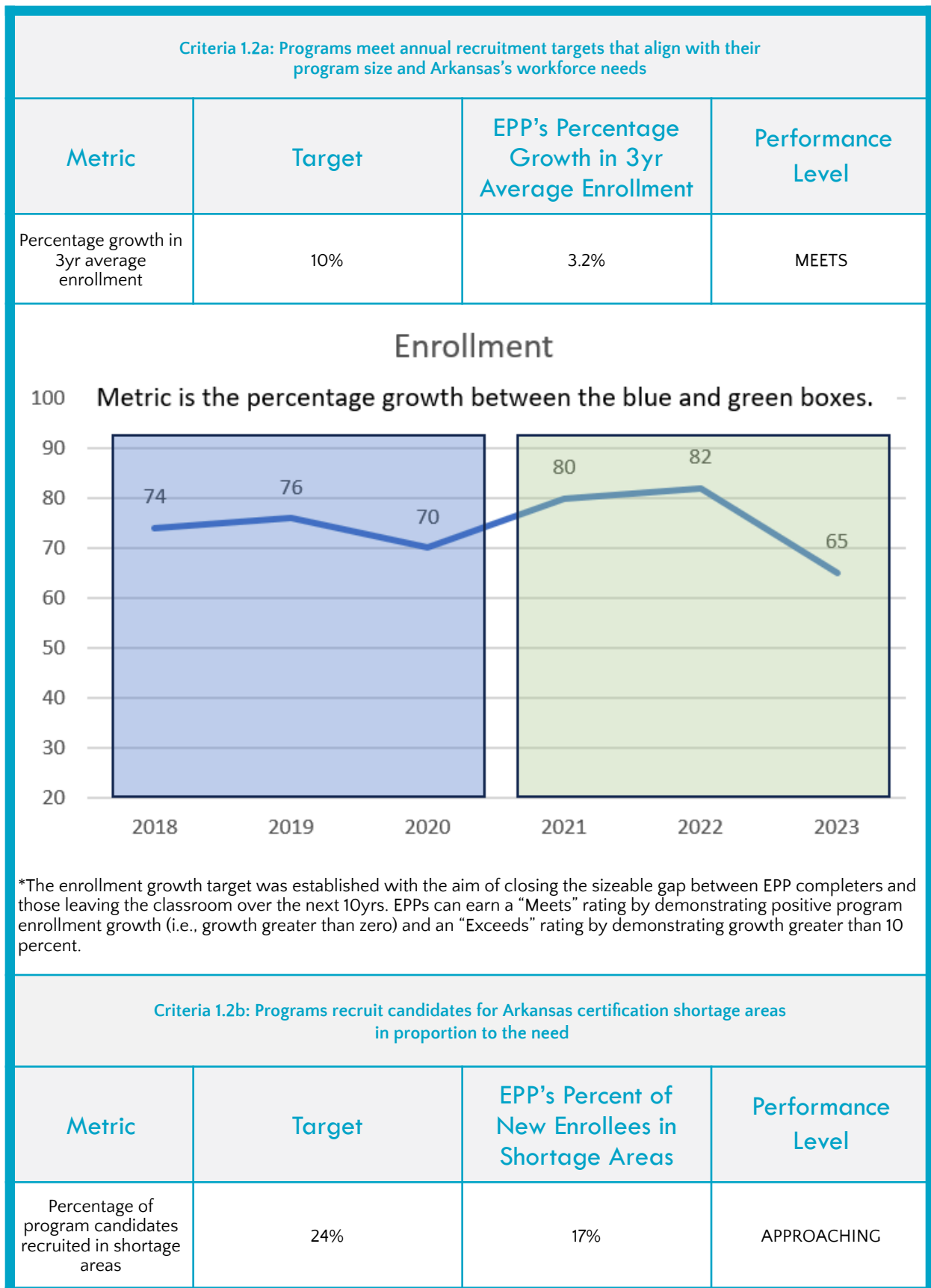
Standard 1: Recruitment & Completion

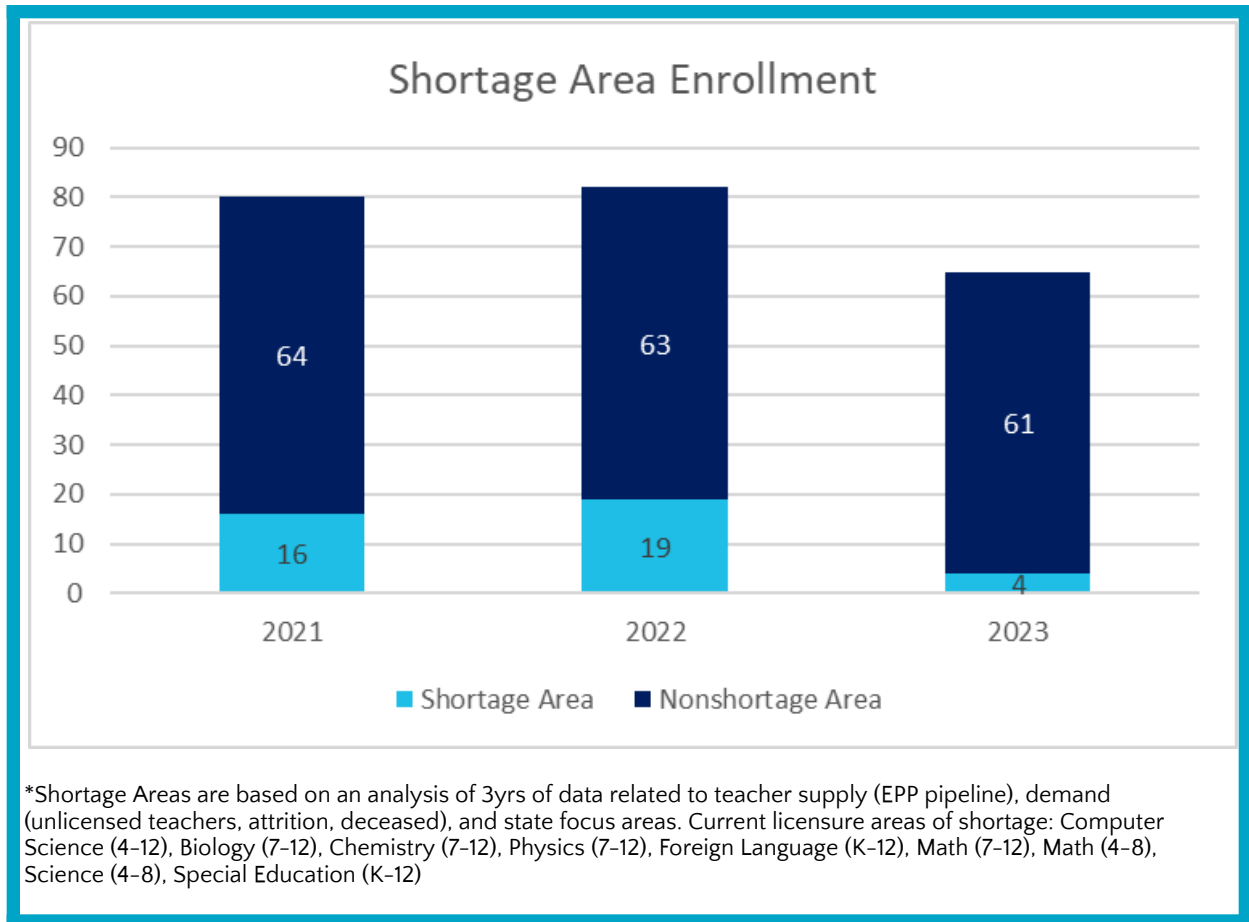
Standard 1 Performance Level		
MEETS		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 1.1 Plans	Indicator 1.2 Recruitment	Indicator 1.3 Completion
MEETS	APPROACHING	EXCEEDS
Recommendations		
Recruiting additional candidates to increase overall enrollment, and particularly in subject shortage areas, will support the program's Standard 1 performance moving forward. (Focus Areas: Criteria 1.2a)		

INDICATOR 1.1: PLANS

Criteria 1.1a: Programs have formal plans to meet the targets described in the state review framework (i.e., Standards 1-3) and show evidence of acting on their plans	
Performance Level	Explanation
MEETS	UAFS has a solid plan for continual growth concerning the indicators in the state frameworks.

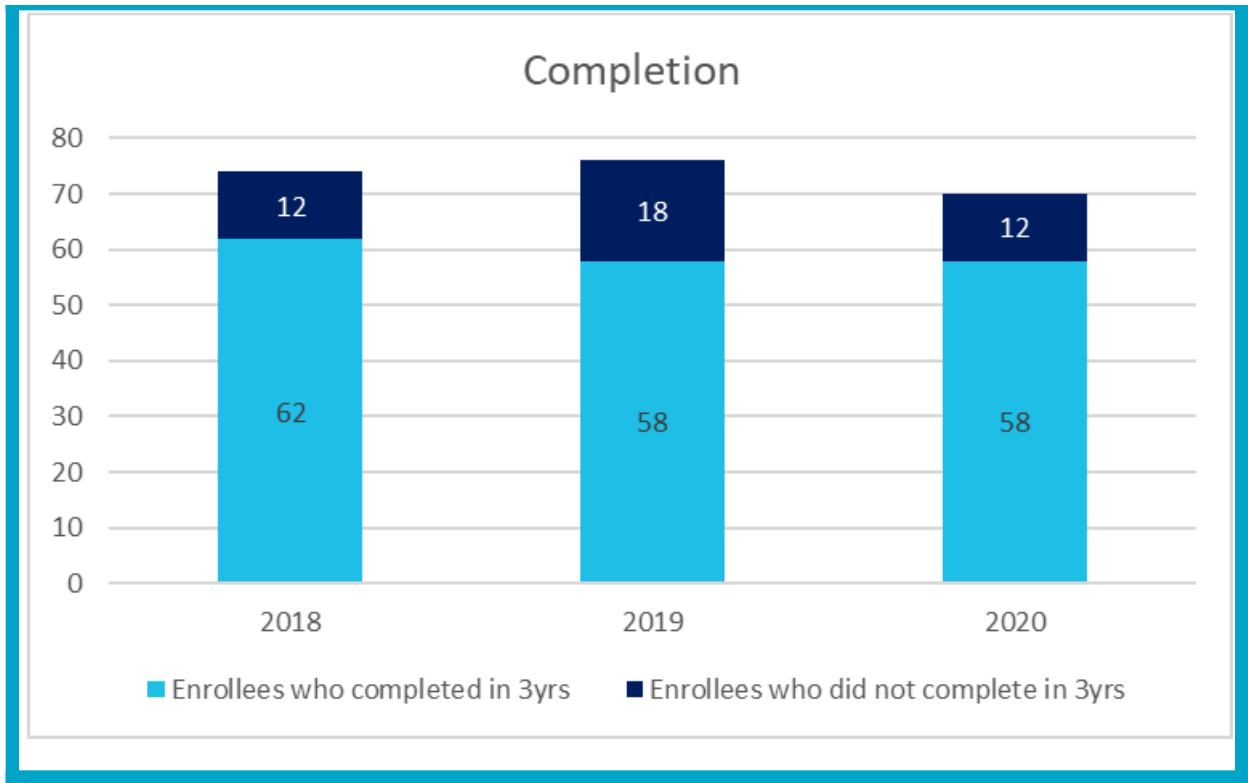
INDICATOR 1.2: RECRUITMENT





INDICATOR 1.3: COMPLETION

Criteria 1.3a: Candidates have high rates of completion			
Metric	Target	EPP's 3-Year Completion Rate	Performance Level
Three-year average completion rate	75%	81%	EXCEEDS



Standard 2: PREPARING CANDIDATES EFFECTIVELY

Standard 2 Performance Level		
MEETS		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 2.1 Coursework	Indicator 2.2 Clinical Experiences	Indicator 2.3 Development
APPROACHING	MEETS	MEETS
Recommendations		
The University of Arkansas – Fort Smith provided evidence of its commitment to preparing traditional teaching candidates with the knowledge, systems, and structures they need to teach in Arkansas schools, including intentionally sequenced clinical experiences and ample opportunities to experience various grade levels and students with varied learning needs. Recommendations to strengthen candidate preparation include: • Provide or provide additional intentional opportunities for students to fully reflect on their coursework and alignment to their clinical internship experiences, especially with their clinical supervisor and mentor teachers. Ensure that all teacher candidates have opportunities to vertically integrate standards throughout their licensure area in their coursework. (<i>Focus Areas: Criteria 2.1a Metric 2, 2.1b Metric 3</i>) • By 2026–2027, EPPs will need to provide evidence that experienced mentor teachers working with year-long residents have received DESE-recognized coaching training (<i>Focus Area: 2.2b Metric 1, Metric 2</i>) • Create or revise clinical internship goals and milestones, and ensure they are communicated to all candidates, course instructors, clinical supervisors, and experienced mentor teachers, and progress towards meeting these milestones is tracked. (<i>Focus Area: Criteria 2.3b, Metric 1</i>)		

INDICATOR 2.1: COURSEWORK

Criteria 2.1a: Candidates receive high-quality program coursework that is evidence-based
APPROACHING
Metric 1: Incorporation and demonstration of best practices around content instruction MEETS Program documentation and course artifacts demonstrate that coursework clearly and intentionally incorporates nationally recognized best practices around content instruction, including the use of High-Quality Instructional Materials (HQIM) and evidence-based literacy practices. Across multiple syllabi—such as <i>EDFD 27843 Introduction to Educational Foundations</i>, <i>EDHP 31053 Practicum I</i>, <i>EDHP 32053 Practicum II</i>, and <i>READ 38043 Literacy Assessment and Intervention</i>—HQIM integration is embedded through assignments requiring lesson design, evaluation of text complexity, and analysis of instructional supports. Reading coursework (READ 33043, READ 35043, and READ 38043) further reflects intentional alignment with the Science of Reading (SoR), emphasizing Scarborough’s Reading Rope, the five pillars of literacy, and structured opportunities for candidates to apply phonemic awareness, decoding, and comprehension strategies. Observation of literacy and practicum sessions confirmed that candidates engage with

authentic HQIM texts and use frameworks such as Marzano’s six-step vocabulary instruction and Depth of Knowledge (DOK) levels to strengthen content rigor and application.

In the teacher candidate focus groups, elementary and middle level candidates (n=13) confirmed that coursework prepares them to evaluate and implement HQIM effectively. Participants described “breaking down standards to make ‘I can’ statements,” aligning lessons to HQIM units, and adapting materials for accommodations. One candidate explained that she “planned lessons around a writing HQIM used in [her] field placement,” while another noted learning to “adjust rigor using DOK levels.” Secondary candidates (n=5) reported more variability, with some, such as English majors, describing clear HQIM examples in coursework, and others, particularly in social studies, noting limited exposure but related discussions with mentor teachers. Candidates across levels highlighted the value of SoR coursework, explaining that these classes “helped [them] prepare for working with struggling readers” and that the content was applicable even in non-ELA placements.

Instructors across multiple programs confirmed that HQIM, SoR, and national content standards are intentionally embedded throughout coursework and field experiences. At least 80% of participating instructors discussed HQIM or SoR integration as central to their teaching, describing structured progression from foundational literacy concepts to applied instructional practice. Observation of lessons, including those using HQIM-approved science texts, showed candidates applying evidence-based methods such as vocabulary tier analysis and scaffolded text structures.

Metric 2: Incorporation and utilization of Arkansas K12 Standards in coursework as a foundation for teacher development

APPROACHING

Review of documentation indicated partial integration of the Arkansas K–12 Standards within coursework and assessment artifacts. Candidate exit portfolios included narratives describing how they used the Arkansas Academic Standards to plan, deliver, and assess instruction; however, it was unclear how these examples demonstrated consistent understanding of grade-level expectations or vertical alignment across licensure bands. Hub 2 “unpacking standards” reflections and secondary assessment portfolios showed candidates identifying standards, creating learning targets, and mapping assessments, with a few including notes on vertical progression. Yet, documentation overall lacked consistent evidence that candidates across all programs deeply analyze, apply, or integrate standards as a developmental framework for instructional design. The EPP’s materials reflected initial but uneven alignment between standards-based planning and candidate understanding of how content builds across grade levels.

In the candidate focus groups (n=13), eight elementary/middle participants and five secondary candidates discussed frequent engagement with Arkansas standards in coursework. In the elementary/middle focus group, participants shared that “we go into materials and find the standard, then plan a lesson around a teaching strategy,” and another described assignments where students “look across standards for progression and overlap.” Secondary candidates provided more variable accounts—one history major described creating a nine-week curriculum map aligned to standards, while another explained she was “just now starting to see it come together.” Participants also cited using Depth of Knowledge levels, “I can” statements, and vertically aligned lesson planning to reinforce understanding of progression across grades. Several noted exposure to multiple grade bands through field experiences, though secondary candidates described more limited vertical integration. Collectively, focus group feedback demonstrated candidate familiarity with Arkansas standards but inconsistent application across content areas and grade levels.

Observation data supported partial incorporation of standards-based instruction. In several lessons, instructors explicitly connected activities to Arkansas Academic Standards, using authentic grade-level texts and prompting candidates to analyze developmental appropriateness. Candidates discussed vocabulary scaffolding and text sequencing aligned to standards, but these links were not always made explicit in instruction. Other observed lessons lacked reference to standards or modeling of how to anchor assessment and differentiation in standards progression. In contrast, one literacy-focused course clearly aligned Science of Reading components to Arkansas English Language Arts Standards and required candidates to identify standards relevant to intervention planning.

Although candidates and faculty spoke to reviewing standards, unpacking standards, and aligning lessons to standards, there was less evidence of standards explicitly referenced in observed coursework, and vertical alignment was minimally referenced by candidates.

Criteria 2.1b: Candidates' coursework supports their development as a teacher

MEETS

Metric 1: Sequence and progression of courses

MEETS

Review of documentation indicated that coursework across programs is clearly and intentionally sequenced to build candidate proficiency and increase rigor over time. Degree plans for all six licensure areas showed coherent progression, beginning with foundational courses and moving toward application in practicum and methods experiences. Review of syllabi demonstrated logical sequencing of content and expectations across hubs, with opportunities for candidates to apply, reflect, and refine their instructional practice as they advance. Exit portfolios provided examples of candidates curating artifacts from multiple courses, demonstrating cumulative learning and reflection on InTASC standards, though the documentation did not directly analyze sequencing. While advising structures were not detailed in the provided evidence, the overall design of coursework across programs reflected intentional progression aligned to developmental and performance expectations.

In the candidate focus groups (n=13), eight elementary/middle and five secondary participants described clear sequencing within their programs that supported skill development and confidence. In the elementary/middle focus group, participants explained that they “moved from foundations of reading into assessment, where we learned how to intervene for struggling students,” and noted that each class “built on the one before.” Secondary candidates confirmed similar patterns, with a math major describing how her coursework “all builds sequentially,” and a history major noting presentations across classes that “helped me build confidence before student teaching.” Participants across both groups described applying knowledge from earlier courses in later assignments and fieldwork, emphasizing that the progression from foundational theory to practical application felt intentional. While secondary candidates referenced sequencing primarily in content courses, elementary and middle candidates more frequently connected their learning to pedagogical growth and field experiences.

In the course instructor focus group (n=8), faculty consistently described the program as intentionally scaffolded, progressing from foundational knowledge in Hub 1 to reinforcement and applied integration in Hubs 2 and 3. Faculty cited examples of candidates moving from designing single lessons to multi-day units, co-teaching, and eventually leading full instructional sequences, reflecting deliberate increases in rigor and responsibility. Participants also described systematic feedback cycles and advising checkpoints, including portfolio reviews and POP cycles, that ensure candidates connect coursework to clinical expectations. Over 80% of faculty provided examples of candidates applying earlier learning—such as vocabulary instruction, standards alignment, or classroom management strategies—in later, more complex contexts. Observations and examples confirmed that course sequencing across hubs supports progressive mastery, coherence, and reinforcement opportunities for growth.

Metric 2: Incorporation and utilization of Arkansas Educator Competencies and Arkansas Teaching Standards in coursework

MEETS

Review of documentation demonstrated that coursework across programs intentionally incorporates the Arkansas Educator Competencies (AEC) and Arkansas Teaching Standards (ATS) to support candidate development aligned with licensure expectations. Alignment matrices for each program of study clearly mapped course objectives to AEC, ATS, High-Quality Instructional Materials (HQIM), and the Aspiring Teacher Rubric (ATR), illustrating structured integration throughout the curriculum. Review of syllabi confirmed embedded references to these frameworks, and multiple courses demonstrated how competencies are applied through planning, instructional design, and reflection activities. The documentation evidenced a coherent structure for developing the knowledge, skills, and dispositions expected of novice teachers, though not all syllabi directly referenced specific competency numbers or performance indicators.

Faculty focus group responses and observation data confirmed that coursework is grounded in the Arkansas standards framework and designed to cultivate essential teaching competencies. Instructors reported using AEC, ATS, and InTASC standards as anchors for course planning, assessment, and self-reflection, with program-wide mapping and checkpoints such as midterm reviews and POP cycles to ensure alignment. Over 80% of instructors shared concrete examples of embedding these frameworks through lesson planning tied to competencies, integration of the Aspiring Teacher Rubric, and portfolio reflections aligned with InTASC standards. Observation data corroborated this alignment: lessons demonstrated modeling of reflective practice, developmental appropriateness, and evidence-based instruction consistent with Arkansas expectations, particularly in literacy and Science of Reading coursework. Although a few observed sessions referenced general practices without explicitly naming the standards, most coursework reflected intentional and consistent integration of the Arkansas Educator Competencies and Teaching Standards.

Metric 3: Alignment of coursework to clinical experience

MEETS

Review of documentation indicated that coursework is intentionally designed to align with clinical experiences through structures such as the Hub model, POP (Plan–Observe–Provide feedback) cycles, and integrated field-based assignments. The EPP’s 2024–2025 Assessment Report described multiple opportunities for candidates to connect theory and practice through formal observations, feedback loops, and reflection tasks. However, distinctions between “formal” and “summative” observations were not fully clarified. Course syllabi and assessment artifacts demonstrated alignment between coursework and clinical expectations, including assignments that parallel classroom practice and require reflection on observed teaching. Data visualizations also emphasized dispositions and reflective growth. While documentation confirms systematic opportunities for candidates to link coursework and clinical application, the specific sequencing of these experiences within the Hub structure was not always clear.

In the candidate focus groups (n=13), eight elementary/middle and five secondary participants described clear and consistent alignment between coursework and field practice. In the elementary/middle focus group, participants noted that “the hours in the classroom feel connected with what we are learning,” with several describing direct application, such as practicing math strategies introduced in coursework during placements. One participant shared that a professor “gave a full page of written feedback after an unannounced observation,” reinforcing growth aligned to teaching competencies. Secondary candidates provided parallel examples, including one who learned a “jigsaw activity” in methods class and implemented it in her field placement, and another who described video-recording and analyzing her own teaching as a structured way to connect coursework to professional standards.

Faculty focus group and observation data further supported intentional alignment of coursework with clinical experiences, though consistency varied by course. Faculty described deliberate coordination across the Hub sequence, with candidates applying concepts from math, literacy, and SPED methods directly during concurrent fieldwork. They referenced structured reflection tools such as POP cycles, mentor feedback, and the Aspiring Teacher Rubric to ensure continuous integration of theory and practice. Over 80% of faculty described coursework requiring candidates to design lessons, implement them in classrooms, and debrief with instructors and peers. Observation data reinforced these patterns: while some lessons did not explicitly connect activities to candidates’ fieldwork, others—particularly in literacy coursework—demonstrated strong alignment through tasks that mirrored real classroom decision-making, such as case studies, intervention planning, and use of HQIM.

Criteria 2.1c: Candidates are provided with knowledgeable and effective course instructors

MEETS

Metric 1: Quality of course instructors

MEETS

Review of documentation provided evidence that most course instructors demonstrate strong content knowledge, hold relevant licensure, and have pedagogical expertise aligned with Arkansas K–12 standards. The faculty roster and supporting documents confirmed that all instructors hold appropriate degrees, with the majority possessing terminal credentials and active teaching licenses. Training records showed participation in Cognitive Coaching and Aspiring Teacher Rubric (ATR) professional learning, though documentation of recent HQIM or AR K–12 standards-specific training was limited. Faculty accomplishments reflected active engagement in scholarly work, including presentations and publications, indicating ongoing professional growth.

In the candidate focus groups (n=13), eight elementary/middle and five secondary participants consistently affirmed that instructors were knowledgeable, passionate, and highly effective. In the elementary/middle focus group, one participant described her professor as “the most knowledgeable person I’ve ever met,” noting the instructor’s rigor and preparation for the Foundations of Reading test. Others cited professors who made Arkansas standards “clear and relevant,” supporting lesson design that included “I can” statements and DOK alignment. Secondary candidates described faculty who modeled scholarly practice and reflective pedagogy, such as an English instructor who shared professional writing drafts to model revision, and a history professor who emphasized aligning curriculum maps to grade-level standards. Across both groups, participants highlighted the faculty’s strong instructional modeling, depth of feedback, and ability to connect content knowledge with pedagogical application.

Faculty focus group and observation data further supported that most instructors demonstrate deep knowledge of standards, content, and pedagogy. Faculty reported over 700 hours of collective professional development in the past year, including HQIM, LTRS, dyslexia training, and instructional coaching. They described aligning syllabi and lessons with the Arkansas Teaching Standards and InTASC, using the ATR to guide feedback and reflection cycles, and

incorporating standards-based planning and assessment into coursework. Observations corroborated these findings: instructors modeled high-quality instructional strategies, demonstrated expertise in the Science of Reading, and employed evidence-based practices like anchor charts, case studies, and collaborative learning.

Metric 2: Effectiveness of course instructors
APPROACHING

Review of documentation indicated that some course instructors demonstrate effective facilitation of coursework and provide meaningful feedback and support to candidates. Evidence included two completed Aspiring Teacher Rubric (ATR) coaching tools and rubrics that outlined expectations for performance across instructional domains. Coaching notes where present were constructive and specific, reflecting individualized feedback aligned to candidate growth. Additional documentation, such as disposition meeting records and Logic of English assignment reflections, suggested consistent communication and attention to the candidate's professional behaviors. However, the EPP did not provide comprehensive data on faculty evaluations, professional effectiveness surveys, or formal measures tracking instructor facilitation quality. While these materials collectively suggest emerging systems of support and reflection, evidence of systematic evaluation of instructional effectiveness was limited.

In the candidate focus groups (n=13), eight elementary/middle and five secondary participants described instructors as organized, responsive, and highly supportive, providing regular, detailed feedback that strengthened their learning. In the elementary/middle focus group, one participant noted that her professor "gave feedback on every assignment," while another described receiving "a full page of notes" following an observed lesson. Candidates praised faculty for adapting coursework to their needs, such as adjusting due dates for Praxis testing or offering flexibility during family challenges. Secondary candidates gave comparable examples of engagement and feedback, highlighting "glows and grows" comments, accessible office hours, and structured activities like fishbowl critiques that fostered participation and reflection.

Faculty focus group and observation data further illustrated examples of strong facilitation and feedback but with variation across instructors. Faculty described shared practices such as "glows and grows" lesson feedback, video coaching, and post-teaching debriefs tied to the ATR. They also emphasized student-centered design through cohort structures and regular check-ins to address academic and dispositional growth. Observations provided mixed but generally positive evidence: most instructors demonstrated clear lesson organization, preparation, and facilitation through scaffolded activities, questioning, and active monitoring, while a few relied heavily on lecture or used outdated frameworks. Several instructors modeled responsive teaching through circulation, formative questioning, and affirmation, while others showed less follow-through in extending candidate thinking.

INDICATOR 2.2: CLINICAL EXPERIENCES

Criteria 2.2a: Candidates are provided clinical experiences throughout their program that support their development as a teacher

MEETS

Metric 1: The sequence of clinical experiences
MEETS

Documentation provides evidence that candidates have a distinct course progression, which increases in the number of hours and the progress of course objectives based on the sequence and progress of the teacher candidate. Additionally, the EPP collects data from practicum experiences for internal use to continually evaluate the program for effectiveness.

Participants in the Clinical Experience focus group (n=2) affirmed that their clinical experiences were intentionally sequenced, gradually increased in rigor, and provided consistent opportunities for development. They provided multiple examples (including interventions, differentiated instruction, and reflective practices) that demonstrated intentional design and supported their readiness to enter the classroom. Candidates described a clear, gradual release model, beginning with structured read-alouds and small interventions and progressing toward full lesson planning, assessment, and classroom leadership during internship. Both noted that reflection, feedback, and increased independence were central to their growth as responsibilities expanded. Participants reported multiple, scaffolded placements across grade levels and subject areas, including required literacy interventions, differentiated instruction, and opportunities to work with students performing below and above grade level. They emphasized that these experiences built their teaching effectiveness and confidence over time. Candidates also noted that they receive a

continuum of goals and milestones from the program, with increasing expectations that align with the Aspiring Teacher Rubric and state standards. They felt these benchmarks prepared them to meet workforce demands and supported the program's stated goal of being "Day 1 ready." Clinical Supervisors described how the HUB system of placements provides a sequence for teacher candidates to have diverse experiences with placements and student interactions.

Metric 2: The variety of clinical experiences
MEETS

Documentation provided by the EPP included the state report cards of partner school demographic data of placement schools, highlighting varied student populations during each HUB placement. The EPP also developed a tracking tool to ensure exposure to a variety of grade levels.

Participants in the Clinical Experience focus group (n=2) reported placements across multiple grade levels (K-8) and subject areas, with each practicum and internship offering different settings and instructional responsibilities. Both participants described working directly with students performing below and above grade level, implementing literacy interventions, and differentiating instruction to meet diverse learning needs. One candidate noted building literacy profiles for focus students, while another emphasized adapting instruction for struggling learners.

Criteria 2.2b: Candidates across the program are provided with an effective clinical internship
APPROACHING

Metric 1: The effectiveness of experienced mentor teachers
APPROACHING

The EPP handbook and MOU state that mentor teachers will provide feedback to teacher candidates; however, artifacts to support feedback to candidates are not included in evidence.

Participants in the Clinical Experience focus group (n=2) described frequent and structured coaching, including daily informal feedback and weekly formal sit-downs with mentors, as well as multiple formal observation cycles with supervisors. They emphasized that both mentor teachers and supervisors provided actionable, data-driven guidance, which they trusted and found supportive of their development. Both focus group participants affirmed strong support from their mentors, citing specific examples such as inclusion in PLCs, feedback on lesson delivery, and strategies for working with struggling learners. They consistently agreed that their mentors were well-equipped and effective in guiding their professional growth. Clinical Supervisors mentioned they provide mentor training, along with meet and greet breakfasts, walkthroughs, and shared the importance of building relationships with mentor teachers.

However, in the Experienced Mentor Teacher focus group (n=4), mentors did not provide clear descriptions of their own coaching approaches or how their feedback aligned with the Aspiring Teacher Rubric. Most feedback examples were general or anecdotal. While a few mentors mentioned receiving training and guidance from the EPP, this was inconsistent across programs.

Note: By 2026-2027, experienced mentor teachers working with year-long residents must have received the DESE-recognized coaching training. [Arkansas Novice Teacher Mentoring Manual](#)

Metric 2: Quality of selection process for experienced mentor teachers
APPROACHING

A partial process is in place to select experienced mentor teachers based on a set of criteria that may include years of experience, demonstrated effectiveness, and depth of content and pedagogical knowledge. The handbook outlines the criteria that must be met for experienced mentor teachers, as well as the MOU with partner schools. The EPP is beginning to track mentor teacher credentials.

Focus group evidence from district partners shows that while there are intentional efforts to match candidates with strong teachers, the process is not yet fully consistent or formalized by the EPP. One district leader shared that mentor selection occurs through collaboration between district administrators and principals, considering credentials, training, and principal recommendations to ensure candidates are paired with strong teachers. However, partners acknowledged that in specialized areas, mentor selection is sometimes based on availability rather than specific qualifications.

Metric 3: Quality of clinical supervisors

MEETS

Documentation provided shows that clinical supervisors are knowledgeable about effective instructional practices and showcase their knowledge through a mentor training where co-teaching strategies are displayed and described.

Both Clinical Experience focus group candidates (n=2) confirmed that their clinical supervisors provided effective coaching, highlighting structured pre- and post-conferences, targeted feedback tied to the Aspiring Teacher Rubric, and concrete next-step strategies. They emphasized that this feedback had a direct positive impact on their instructional practice, including improving differentiation and supporting struggling learners. Candidates reported that supervisors consistently engaged them in formal observation cycles, provided written and oral feedback, and anchored guidance in student data and rubric domains. Supervisors were described as organized and developmental in their approach, using the POP cycle, Glows/Grows feedback, and domain-based scoring to scaffold candidate growth over time.

Reviewers saw strong evidence of coaching in four of the five coaching observations. One review team noted that the clinical supervisor “is knowledgeable regarding pedagogy and training completed by the CS was implemented during the pre- and post-conference with the questioning for methods to improve the lesson in particular, but also enhancing future lessons by reflective thought.” They saw evidence of written feedback within the ATR that was complete and succinct for the teacher candidate to understand and provided actionable steps moving forward with a positive impact.

Metric 4: Quality of feedback to candidates

MEETS

Candidates consistently receive high-quality feedback from their clinical supervisor that is frequent, both written and oral, connected to the Aspiring Teacher Rubric, clearly linked to evidence of student learning during observed lessons, and built on the previous feedback. The program handbook speaks to systems in place and the consistency of feedback

Both participants in the Clinical Experience focus group affirmed receiving frequent, high-quality feedback from their mentor teachers and clinical supervisors, including daily informal guidance, weekly formal check-ins, and multiple structured observation cycles. They described feedback as specific, data-driven, and tied to the Aspiring Teacher Rubric, with clear next steps that supported their professional growth and instructional effectiveness. They discussed the POP cycles and how their observations scaffold upon each other and inform their areas of growth.

In four of the five coaching observations, reviewers observed strong feedback. In one observation, the review team noted that the clinical supervisor provided feedback on specific actions like participation and effective closure. During the pre-conference, the site coordinator used questioning to assess the candidate’s knowledge of the instructional choices. While the candidate noted that much of the plan was provided by the mentor teacher, the site coordinator used questioning to assess the candidate’s own instructional adjustments, like turn-and-talks and guided questioning. Post-conference feedback explicitly referenced the Aspiring Teacher Rubric with suggestions for next steps, such as improved pacing and distributing questions across tables. In another observation, reviewers noted that during the pre- and post-conference discussions, the clinical supervisor provided feedback that directly addressed the candidate’s instructional choices and built on previous guidance. The supervisor modeled effective instructional practices, including planning for vocabulary integration, scaffolding comprehension, and using Kagan strategies to increase engagement, while helping the candidate to reflect on how these strategies supported learning goals. The discussions demonstrated a clear coaching cycle, with the site coordinator asking, “Based on this feedback, what would you set as your next goal?” and referencing the next scheduled session.

Note: The Aspiring Teacher Rubric must be in use by EPPs by the 2024-25 academic year.

Criteria 2.2c: Strong partnerships exist between the EPP and K12 schools and districts that facilitate the development of strong candidates

MEETS

Metric 1: Quality of partnership with districts/schools

MEETS

Collaborative processes are in place with most districts/schools to co-construct the clinical internship for candidates, including but not limited to collaboration between experienced mentor teachers and clinical supervisors. The EPP has established annual governance meetings with partner K12 schools, where data is analyzed for future effectiveness of the program. The EPP also hosts Mentor Breakfast training for the different HUB pathways and attributes the effectiveness of the mentor and their ability to coach their teacher candidate into a strong candidate.

Participants in the School Partnership focus group (n=3) indicated strong communication and shared ownership of the partnership between the EPP and its K-12 partners. District leaders described both formal and informal communication structures, including meetings with principals and assistant superintendents to review progress and make improvements to the HUB experiences. One partner noted that EPP faculty are “a part of our district all day, every day, like they’re employed here.” In addition, all three district leaders confirmed that communication between mentors and site coordinators is frequent and effective.

Metric 2: Support and development for clinical supervisors

MEETS

Clinical Supervisors are provided with development and support. Documentation shows that clinical supervisors participate in various trainings, including Cognitive Coaching, John Wink Coaching Training, HQIM, and Aspiring Teacher Rubric. The EPP has monthly guiding coalition meetings, where available training from a partner K12 district or state-level training is offered for completion. Additionally, mentor training with partner K12 schools assists in the development of clinical supervisor communication traits, creating high-quality feedback, and fostering accountability in the preparation of teacher candidates.

All participants in the Clinical Supervisor focus group (n=6) agree that the EPP directly or indirectly provides support and professional development opportunities. They gave specific examples that included participation in EPP communities of practice focused on HQIM, coordinating with the education co-op for literacy training, participating in PD with partner school districts, and completing cognitive coaching.

INDICATOR 2.3: DEVELOPMENT

Criteria 2.3a: Candidates are successful with their program coursework

MEETS

Metric 1: Candidate proficiency in coursework

MEETS

Candidates show proficiency in coursework requirements. GPA data from the Navigate system shows that term GPA is at or above 3.0, on average, for the past 10 semesters. The Fall 2025 GPA Tracker shows that over 85% of current candidates have a GPA of 3.0 or above.

Metric 2: Quality of candidate support across coursework

MEETS

Candidates are consistently provided with an individualized support plan if their coursework requirements are not on track by meeting with faculty from the SOE to discuss concerns and develop action steps, and they take an active role in creating the plan and monitoring progress. The Contract for Improvement is created during a collaborative support meeting alongside the candidate with measurable goals and required evidence. Timelines for completion are explicitly outlined to ensure consistent progress monitoring.

Clinical Supervisors described a system for referring candidates who are off track, which may begin with informal feedback and progress to a formal “contract for improvement.” These support plans are tailored to the candidate, outlining specific steps and timelines, and are monitored collaboratively by course instructors, hub leaders, and sometimes counseling staff; in rare cases, a second contract is issued if growth is not sufficient. Participants noted that candidates who struggle are actively supported through weekly check-ins, individualized coaching, extensions for extenuating circumstances, and clear expectations such as completing Praxis or Foundations of Reading exams. More than 80% of instructors described examples of how support plans are developed and implemented, and candidates were able to share experiences of receiving targeted help.

Criteria 2.3b: Candidates are successful in their clinical internship

MEETS

Metric 1: Candidate attainment of clinical internship goals and milestones

APPROACHING

Evidence of goals and milestones was not seen in the documentation. A sample candidate lesson plan was provided in addition to the tiered Aspiring Teacher Rubric, with look-fors used as the coaching tool for observations. However, there was no evidence of explicit internship goals and milestones, nor evidence of how candidates were aware of expectations.

However, in the Clinical Experience and Clinical Supervisor focus groups, participants talked about goals and milestones. Candidates reported receiving a continuum of goals and milestones beginning in Practicum 1 and continuing through internship, such as learning student names, gathering student interests, and differentiating instruction based on that knowledge. They were able to cite concrete examples of these checkpoints, demonstrating a clear understanding of program expectations. Supervisors shared that candidates must pass their Praxis exams before admittance into HUB 1. Midterm disposition benchmark aligns teacher candidates with EPP requirements and allows for the establishment of improvement contracts based on performance.

Metric 2: Candidate impact on student growth

MEETS

There is adequate evidence that candidates have the capacity to impact student growth. Exit Portfolios include lesson plans, assessments, student work samples, and reflective analyses showing how candidates measure and respond to student progress. Across all program levels, students demonstrated measurable learning gains. For example, elementary students improved from 20% to 77.8% satisfactory, middle school students showed improvement across all four assessed areas, and secondary students increased mastery from 63.9% to 83.85% in the provided sample portfolios. In addition, the Aspiring Teacher Rubric provides evidence of candidate performance, breaking down each component to identify demonstrated behaviors and providing “glow and grow” feedback. Candidates also engage in Diversity Case Studies where they design and implement targeted interventions for individual students, analyze pre- and post-assessment results, and evaluate the quality of their chosen assessments. Lesson Reflections include responses to Professional Learning Community (PLC) guiding questions, such as “How do I know if every student learned the goal of the lesson?”.

All candidates in the Clinical Experience focus group provided concrete examples of using data to impact student learning, from early practice with “mock” datasets to applying daily formative assessment results to adapt teaching strategies. They agreed that consistent emphasis on data analysis throughout the program had strengthened their instructional effectiveness. Candidates described frequent use of student data to inform instruction, including analyzing daily assessments, formative math pull-downs, and student work samples. They noted that this data was routinely used to adjust small groups, scaffold lessons, and plan interventions to better meet learner needs. Participants reported structured opportunities to build literacy profiles, track interventions, and use program assignments to connect assessment data to instructional decision-making. They also emphasized that reflection on student outcomes was built into each practicum and reinforced during internship, supporting their ability to analyze and act on evidence of student learning. Clinical Supervisors shared an assignment in which candidates are assigned two intervention lessons and can see their direct impact on student growth. The candidate also establishes goals for their assigned student and where they want them to be at certain points.

Metric 3: Candidate proficiency in effective teaching skills

MEETS

Most candidates receive a score of “effective” on the Aspiring Teacher Rubric at the end of their clinical internship. The SOE Annual Assessment Report shows that the majority of candidates in both ELML and Secondary programs received Effective ratings on their Summative evaluation at the end of their internship. In the 24–25 academic year, for ELML, 85% or more of the candidates scored Effective or Highly Effective on all components in their final observation. For Secondary, 100% of candidates were rated Effective or Highly Effective on their final internship observation.

Note: By 2024–25, evidence that the Aspiring Teacher Rubric is in use by EPPs must be shown to meet this metric.

Metric 4: Quality of candidate support across clinical internship

MEETS

Struggling candidates are provided with an individualized support plan if their development is not on track. There is evidence of a support system that includes individual improvement contracts. In addition, the roles and responsibilities of clinical support roles, including mentor teachers, site coordinators, and school principals, are explicitly outlined in the Teacher Candidate Manual.

Candidates in the Clinical Experience focus group (n=2) shared that when they felt overwhelmed or uncertain (such as managing student engagement during observations), supervisors provided targeted, concrete strategies to support daily practice. They also noted that both mentors and supervisors gave continuous “glows and grows” feedback, ensuring that areas of struggle were addressed with actionable next steps. Both candidates affirmed the program’s emphasis on being “Day 1 ready” and stated that their experiences had prepared and motivated them to continue in the profession. They described the clinical sequence and strong mentorship as positive factors that built their confidence and commitment to remain in teaching.

Clinical supervisors discussed how they recognize high-performing candidates, including encouraging them to apply for the student apprentice program, highlighting teachers in their social media posts, and utilizing their teacher candidates as ambassadors for their program by providing them with leadership opportunities.

STANDARD 3: SUPPORTING WORKFORCE NEEDS

Standard 3 Performance Level		
EXCEEDS		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 3.1 Licensure	Indicator 3.2 Employment	Indicator 3.3 Effectiveness
EXCEEDS	MEETS	EXCEEDS
Recommendations		
Recommendations include: Support program completers to work in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects to increase the percentage of licensed teachers who take this type of job in the first three years after completion. (<i>Focus Areas: Criteria 3.2b</i>)		

INDICATOR 3.1: LICENSURE

Criteria 3.1a: A high proportion of program candidates obtain a standard license			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Licensed	Performance Level

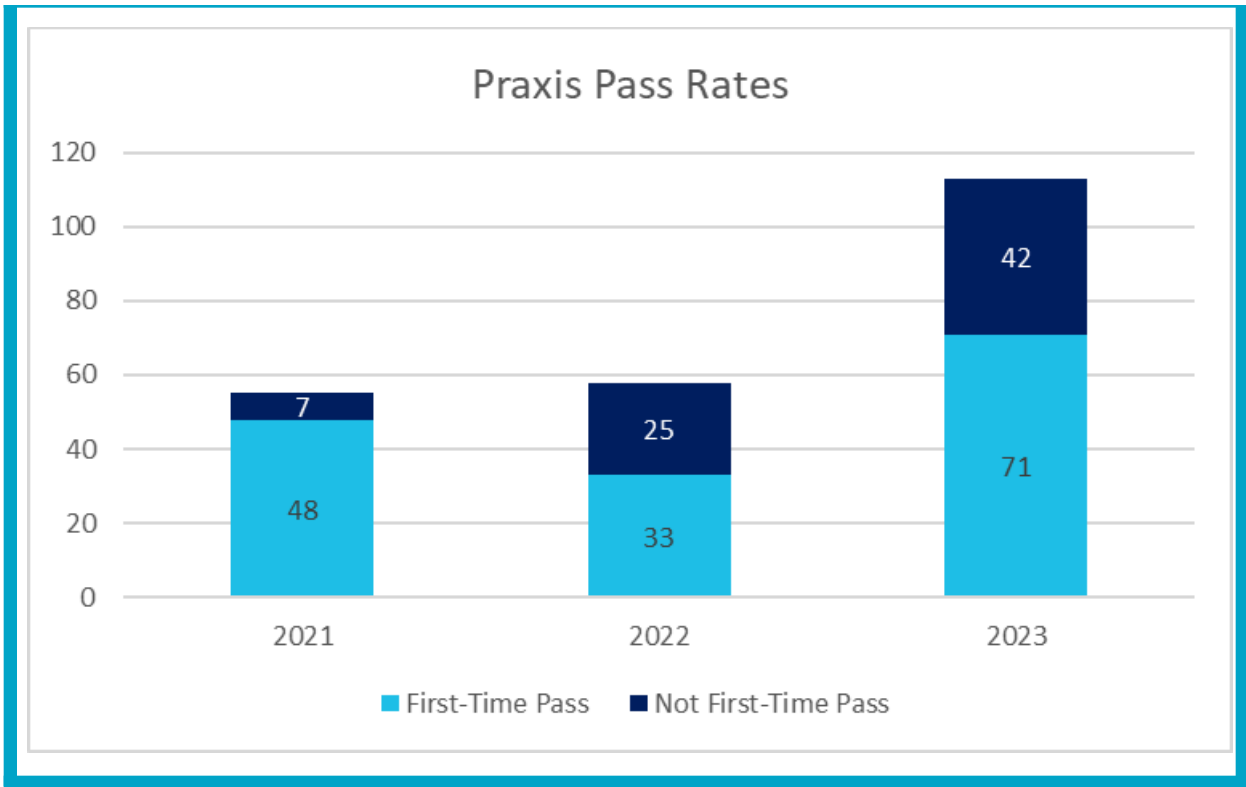
Percentage of completers who have earned a standard license	80%	90%	EXCEEDS
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Licensure

Year	Licensed	Not Licensed
2021	53	8
2022	57	4
2023	57	6

Criteria 3.1b: A high proportion of alternative route enrollees are provisionally licensed			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Licensed	Performance Level
Percentage of employed alternative route enrollees who are provisionally licensed	73%	n/a	n/a

Criteria 3.1c: A high proportion of traditional program candidates pass the content exam in their area on the first try			
Metric	Target	EPP's First-Time Pass Percentage	Performance Level
Percentage of first-time licensure exam test takers that pass on their first try	66%	67%	EXCEEDS



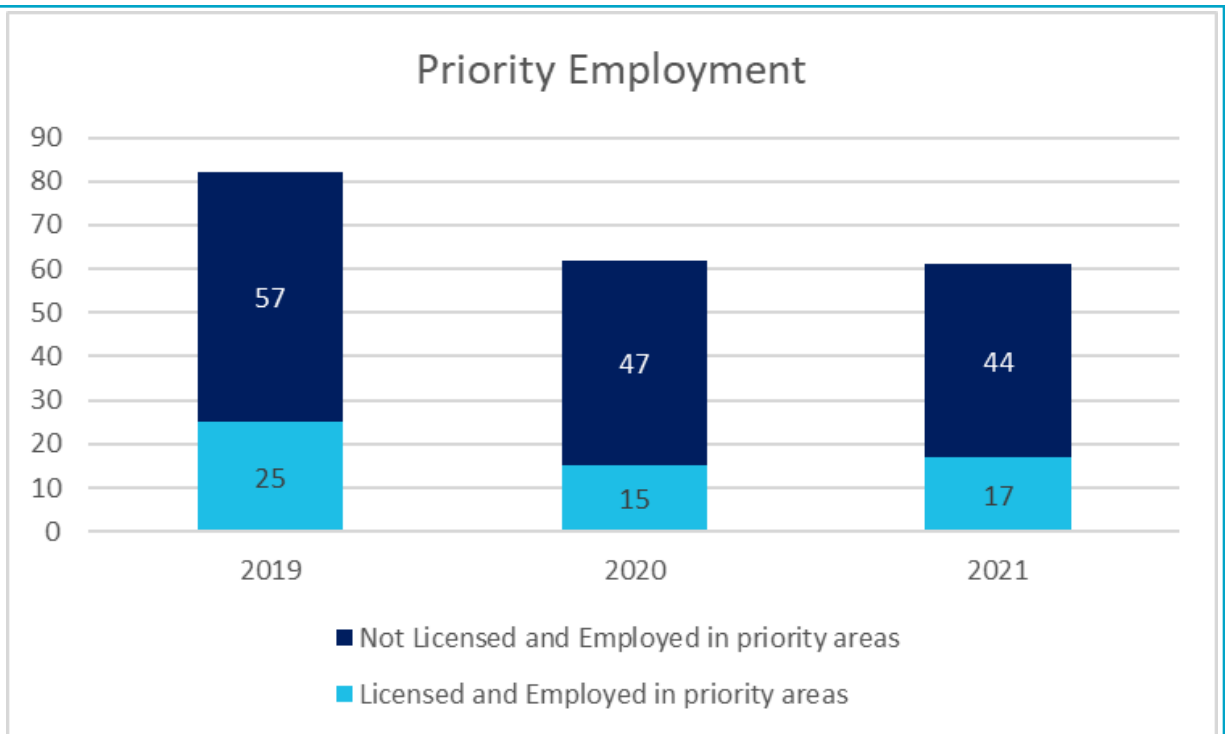
INDICATOR 3.2: EMPLOYMENT

Criteria 3.2a: A high proportion of completers are employed in Arkansas public schools			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Employed	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in Arkansas public schools in their first three years after completion	68%	75%	EXCEEDS

Employment

Year	Licensed and Employed	Not Licensed and Employed
2019	53	29
2020	51	11
2021	50	11

Criteria 3.2b: A high proportion of completers work in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Employed Priority	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects in their first three years after completion	39%	28%	BELOW



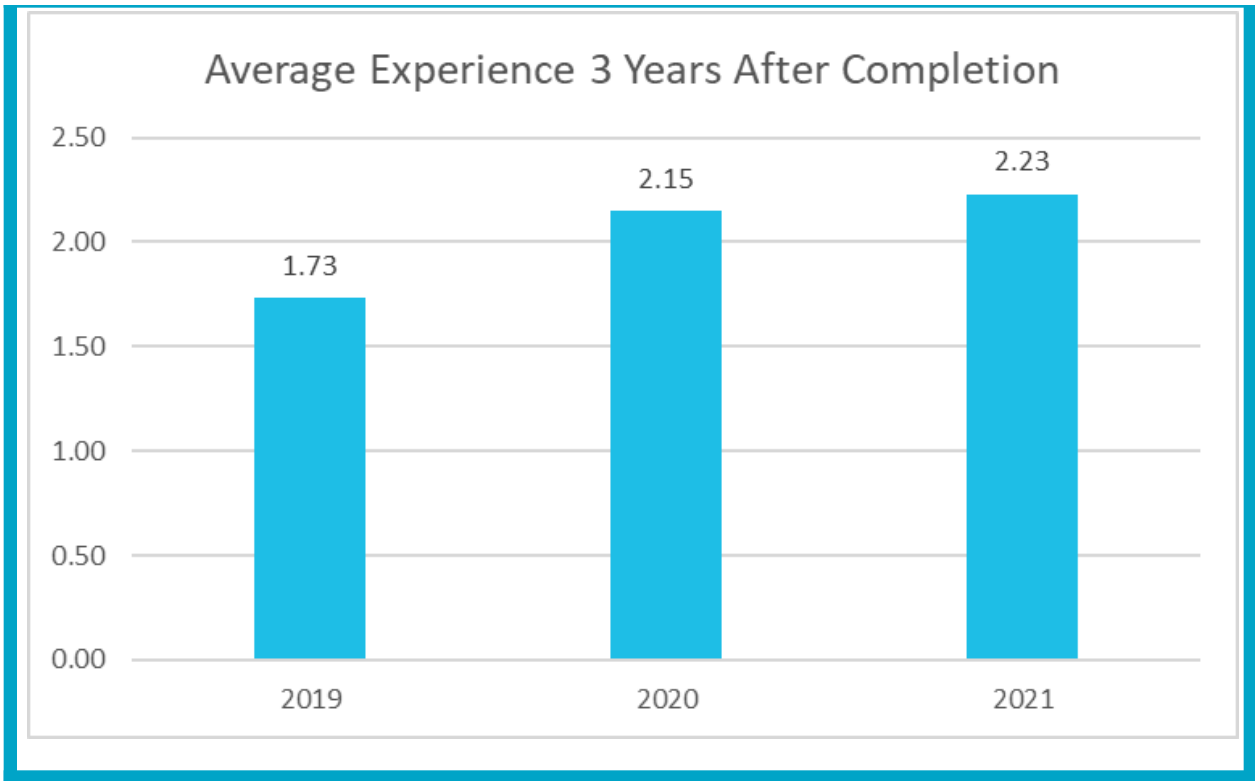
*Priority Employment is employment in a high-need subject area and/or geographical shortage area. Shortage Areas are based on an analysis of 3yrs of data related to teacher supply (EPP pipeline) and demand (unlicensed teachers, attrition, deceased) and state focus areas.

Current subject shortage areas for employment: Computer Science, Secondary Science, Foreign Language, Secondary Math, Middle School Math, Middle School Science, and Special Education.

Current geographical shortage areas are school districts located in the following co-op regions: Arkansas River ESC, Great Rivers ESC, Pulaski Co Schools, Southeast AR ESC.

Criteria 3.2c: Program completers remain in the classroom for multiple years

Metric	Target	EPP's Average Years of Experience, 3 Years After Completion	Performance Level
Program completers' average licensed teaching experience in Arkansas's public schools 3 years after completion	1.8	2	EXCEEDS



INDICATOR 3.3: EFFECTIVENESS

Criteria 3.3a: School leaders rate program completers that they hire as effective classroom teachers			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ on all Survey Items	Performance Level
School leaders' perception of program completer effectiveness based on responses to the EPP Completer Supervisor Survey conducted annually by the DESE	78%	83%	EXCEEDS
Criteria 3.3b: Completers feel that their program prepared them well to be a teacher			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ on all Survey Items	Performance Level
Program completers' perception of how well their program prepared them to be a teacher based on responses to the EPP Completer Survey conducted annually by the DESE	79%	83%	EXCEEDS
Criteria 3.3c: A high proportion of program completers have above-average value-added scores			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage with Average Value-Added of 80+	Performance Level
Percentage of program completers who have above-average value-added scores in their first three years after completion	43%	45%	EXCEEDS

